visited his office again and was told that the schools in Aizawl (the capital of Mizoram) were 'bad' and that she should reconsider her request. Her daughter Saina (also called Guchu) had completed her tenth standard from the Convent of Jesus and Mary, New Delhi, and so she consulted officers who had served in Mizoram about the real situation regarding schools there. They told her that although there was nothing much to write home about, yet the situation was manageable. Armed with this knowledge she went right back to the joint secretary's office and told the officials concerned that she had reconsidered her request and stood by it. There was still no response from the joint secretary's office for another long period and then finally they communicated to her that they could offer her the post of vigilance officer of the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC).

The joint secretary's office was, therefore, obviously a dead end and so she wrote to the home secretary about her request. The occupant of this post, Naresh Kumar, informed the joint secretary that if she was volunteering for the hard area posting, then he should rightly accept her offer and send her there. Meanwhile, feelers were sent to her that, if she had no objections, she could be sent to Jammu and Kashmir because they needed women officers there to handle the women agitators. The obvious gender bias towards an officer who had put in eighteen years of service was very offensive and she conveyed a polite 'no'. Finally, a batch mate, Parminder Singh, and a common friend of Kiran and the joint secretary, persuaded the latter to let her go, pointing out that whereas officers who were given the Mizoram posting refused to accept it, here was one who was volunteering for it and the official was not acceding to her request. After that, she received orders to report to the Mizoram Government on 27 April 1990. She left immediately.

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She had wanted a change and a change she most certainly did get. A change from the pollution, overcrowding, chaos and noise of Delhi to the serenity of open tracts with pure air and plenty of space; from the sequence of one tightly scheduled day to another, she could now get back to the tidiness and purposefulness of regular office hours; from precious moments snatched for reading even an article to ample time for leisurely indulgence in books; and from early morning newspapers to virtually no newspapers at all!

It was indeed a much required change. For the first time in her eighteen years of service she was having regular lunch with her family and also returning home at 5 p.m. sharp. Essentially a home-loving person, she was enjoying the closeness of family life almost for the first time in her career. There was a tennis court at a walking distance and the office was only twenty steps below. (The house was on a hillock.) There was not much scope for shopping and she could even economize a little.

Vegetables were very difficult to come by because (as already stated) the Mizos are essentially meat eaters and thrive on pork, beef, mutton, poultry, fish and dogs. They can comfortably manage without vegetables, milk and milk products. Kiran and her family gave up eating chicken only when they realized that they could not get a dressed chicken there. Once they had asked the cook to prepare chicken and learnt this fact when they saw him dressing the chicken at home. That effectively put an end to chicken during lunches and dinners.

The area of Mizoram is vast and the terrain rugged. The state was sparsely populated and because of lack of any good system of roads, it was highly inaccessible. Because of this lack of interlinking roads, very little ethnic bonding existed among the tribals living there. Moreover, economic development activities and facilities for education were almost negligible. The people living in the interiors and the remote villages were, by and large, very discontented with their lot. Such areas